Document 3: Footwear Guide

Harbour & Pine Outdoor Co. Hiking Boots and Footwear Guide

This guide explains how to choose, fit, break in and look after your hiking footwear. Good boots that fit well make a trip enjoyable, and poorly fitting ones can ruin it.

Our footwear range

We make three styles. The Ridgeline is a low-cut hiking shoe for day walks on good paths. It is the lightest of the three and costs $129. The Summit Trail is a mid-height waterproof boot with ankle support, made from fabric and synthetic leather, for longer walks and rougher ground. It costs $179. The Granite is our full-grain leather backpacking boot for carrying heavy loads over several days. It costs $259.

All three come in US men’s sizes 7 to 14 and US women’s sizes 5 to 11.

Getting the right fit

Try on boots in the late afternoon, because your feet swell during the day and swell more when you walk. Wear the socks you plan to hike in. Stand up and check that you have about a thumb’s width of space, roughly 1 cm, in front of your longest toe. Your toes should not touch the front of the boot when you walk downhill. Your heel should hold firmly with very little lift when you walk uphill. Lift is when your heel slides up inside the boot.

If you are between sizes, choose the larger size and use a thicker sock or a cushioned insole. Feet are rarely identical, so always fit to the larger foot.

Socks

Wear hiking socks made from merino wool or a wool blend. Wool keeps your feet comfortable when they get damp and helps stop blisters. Avoid cotton socks. Cotton holds moisture against your skin and is a common cause of blisters. Carry a spare pair on long walks.

Breaking in your boots

New boots need time to soften and mould to your feet. The Ridgeline and the Summit Trail need about a week of short walks. The Granite is made from stiffer leather and needs longer, about two weeks of wearing the boots for one to two hours a day. Wear them around the house first, then on short walks, and then on a longer walk with a loaded pack. Do not wear brand new boots on a long hike.

Stop and deal with sore spots straight away. A hot spot is a patch of skin that feels warm and rubbed before a blister forms. Cover it with a blister plaster or tape before it gets worse.

Lacing tips

If your heel lifts, use a heel lock. Thread the laces through the top two eyelets on each side so that they make a loop, cross the laces through the opposite loops and pull tight before tying. If the top of your foot feels sore, loosen the laces over the sore spot, or skip a pair of eyelets. For long downhill sections, pull the laces tight at the ankle so your foot does not slide forward.

Cleaning your boots

After each hike, take out the insoles and knock off loose mud. Clean the boots with a soft brush and lukewarm water. Do not use hot water or strong detergent. Dry the boots at room temperature, stuffed loosely with newspaper, and keep them away from radiators, fires and hairdryers. Heat makes leather crack and can weaken the glue that holds the sole.

Waterproofing and storage

Treat the Granite leather boots with a wax-based waterproofer about every 3 months if you hike regularly. The Summit Trail and the Ridgeline use fabric, so use a spray-on waterproofer about every 6 months. Always treat boots when they are clean and slightly damp. Store boots in a cool, dry place, not in a sealed plastic bag.

Resoling

The Granite can be resoled once when the sole is worn, which extends the life of the boot by several years. Our resoling service costs $85 and takes about 15 business days. The Summit Trail and the Ridgeline cannot be resoled.

Returns and sizing

If your boots do not fit, try them on indoors on a clean floor or carpet only. Boots that have not been worn outdoors can be returned under our standard returns policy within 30 days of delivery. Return the pair in its original packaging and order the correct size. Once a pair has been worn outside, it can no longer be returned unless it is faulty. Faulty footwear is covered by our warranty for 1 year.